

device could be an economical way to access a non-smartphone OS-based computing environment.

The Windows 365 Link's small size makes it ideal for minimalist users – both in terms of desk space and overall computing experience. It's comparable to the Mac mini in size and could easily blend into a home office or living room environment. Anyone who's online in 2024 is already a heavy user of cloud-based applications, whether it's OTT streaming services or Google Docs – the Windows 365 Link just takes this a step further by streaming the entire Windows 11 desktop through the internet. This means all your PC settings, applications, and files are accessible from anywhere, irrespective of any hardware limitations.

For less tech-savvy consumers, think of elders in your family (for instance), the Windows 365 Link reduces potential headaches. In theory, your offline device isn't a single point of failure for all of your data anymore. Since everything's in the cloud, Windows operating system updates and cybersecurity events are handled automatically as well.

Challenges of Windows 365 Link

Of course, the Windows 365 Link isn't without its drawbacks – the biggest one being its reliance on a consistent (and high-speed) internet connection. Since the device streams Windows 11 operating system from the cloud, it's essentially a brick if your internet's down or if it's slow (not above a certain recommended speed threshold). Naturally, for consumers in areas with erratic and unreliable internet, this computing device is simply a non-starter.

Unlike traditional desktop PCs, or the Mac mini for that matter, the Windows 365 Link doesn't store data or applications locally. Which means if your internet goes down, so does

your ability to use the device – this limitation could be a big no-no for users who need access to their computers at all times, of course.

Total cost of ownership is another concern, because accessing Windows 365 requires a subscription right now, which could add to the overall cost of owning the Windows 365 Link for the average consumer. Paying more and not having the ability to customise and tweak the system to their liking pretty much makes this device not worthy of Windows power users as well.

Why the Windows 365 Link should have a consumer variant?

Despite the cons, there's a compelling case for Microsoft to bring the Windows 365 Link to the consumer

segment, offering a Windows-based alternative. As a long-time observer and user of Microsoft's products through the 1990s, I definitely see the Windows 365 Link as more than just a business tool.

It's a window into the future of computing, where local and cloud-based experiences converge. For Microsoft, the Windows 365 Link presents an opportunity to further refine what personal computing means for end users.

Of course, challenges exist. Internet infrastructure varies widely, and not all users are ready to embrace a fully cloud-dependent device. However, with thoughtful implementation and perhaps hybrid solutions that offer some offline capabilities, Microsoft could mitigate these concerns.



market. By offering an affordable, easy-to-use device, Microsoft could empower more people to participate in the digital world. Students, senior citizens, and developing regions on the wrong side of the digital divide could benefit immensely from such computing platforms.

Apple's Mac mini has demonstrated over the years that there's consumer appetite for a sleek, compact desktop experience. Windows 365 Link gives Microsoft the opportunity to tap into this market

At least in my humble view, the Windows 365 Link has all the makings of a device that could leave its mark on the consumer PC market. By addressing the cons and leveraging the pros,

Microsoft has the chance to offer a compelling alternative to the Mac mini and other compact PCs in the market. As we move toward a more digitally connected and cloud-centric world, devices like the Windows 365 Link could become the norm rather than the exception. **d**